

Print-on-Demand Services

Cost Comparison Analysis for Ecommerce

Prepared for ecommerce vendor selection and client proposal planning

Benchmark product	Bella+Canvas 3001 / premium unisex crewneck-style tee, one front print, shipped to a U.S. customer
Sort order	Estimated product + U.S. shipping cost, lowest to highest
Not included	Shopify subscription, payment processing, taxes/VAT, returns, samples, ad spend, or customer service time
Prepared date	May 5, 2026

Executive Summary

For a lean ecommerce T-shirt/apparel business, the best overall starting stack is: **Printify** for margin testing, **Printful** for reliable premium fulfillment, **Gelato** for global/local production, **CustomCat** for U.S.-based fast fulfillment, and **Gooten** as a scale-oriented alternative that needs closer monitoring.

Practical recommendation: start with Printify for margin testing, order samples from Printify, Printful, and CustomCat, and reserve Printful for premium or branded items where consistency matters more than the lowest cost.

Recommended setup for a salty bartender T-shirt brand: Primary vendor = Printify. Backup/premium vendor = Printful. U.S. margin test = CustomCat. Optional global/art expansion = Gelato.

Cost Comparison: Lowest to Highest

Rank	Service	Product Cost	U.S. Ship	Est. Total	Speed / Fulfillment	Quality Signal	Best For
1	Printify	~\$8.32	\$4.75	~\$13.15	U.S. shipping listed around 2-5 days; depends heavily on chosen provider.	Shopify 4.7/5 from 3,206 reviews; strong flexibility and catalog.	Low-cost testing, large catalogs, Etsy/Shopify.
2	Gooten	From \$8.65	From \$4.95	~\$13.60	Product page lists avg. production ~1.5 days and U.S. shipping ~3 days; broader FAQ says 2-5 business days.	Shopify 3.5/5 from 145 reviews; weaker public review signal.	Scale operations, product variety, API-style fulfillment.
3	Gelato	\$10.69 or \$8.55 with Gelato+	From \$4.99	~\$15.68 or ~\$13.54 with Gelato+	U.S. delivery around 4-6 business days; local/global production network.	Shopify 4.8/5 from 817 reviews; strong global reach.	International customers, global shipping, art prints.
4	Printful	\$11.69	From \$4.75	~\$16.44	Average fulfillment 2-5 business days; over 97% ship within 5 business days.	Shopify 4.8/5 from 3,115+ reviews; strong reliability.	Premium brand experience, consistency, embroidery.
5	CustomCat	\$11.47 Lite or \$8.67 Pro	~\$4.99	~\$16.46 Lite or ~\$13.66 Pro	Most items produced and shipped within 3 business days; ships from Detroit, MI.	Shopify 4.3/5 from 103 reviews; fast production and service.	U.S.-based apparel sellers and Pro margin play.

1. Printify - Best for margins and product testing

Strongest choice for low upfront cost, large product selection, flexible pricing, and the ability to choose providers.

Weak spot: marketplace model means quality and speed vary by print provider, so samples matter.

Best use: shirt design testing, large catalogs, Etsy/Shopify stores, and products where margin matters.

2. Gooten - Good pricing and scale, weaker public review signal

Attractive benchmark pricing and speed metrics for the Bella+Canvas 3001.

Weak spot: lower public Shopify review score than the other vendors in this comparison; monitor before making it primary.

Best use: larger or more operationally mature stores that want a broader supply-chain-style POD partner.

3. Gelato - Best global/local production play

No upfront fees, no commission, and no minimum orders on its base model. Strongest advantage is distributed global production.

Weak spot: partner production can make quality less predictable than a vendor controlling all facilities directly.

Best use: global ecommerce, art prints/posters, international customers, and local production advantages.

4. Printful - Best reliability and brand-safe fulfillment

Not the cheapest, but one of the safest choices for brand consistency, fulfillment reliability, custom branding, packaging, and integrations.

Weak spot: higher product costs; margins get tight unless shipping is charged separately or pricing is more premium.

Best use: flagship products, branded customer experience, embroidery, premium catalog items, or high-trust SKUs.

5. CustomCat - Best U.S. margin option if Pro makes sense

Very competitive when the Pro plan is justified. U.S.-based, ships from Detroit, and emphasizes fast production.

Weak spot: smaller public review base and less global infrastructure than Printify, Printful, or Gelato.

Best use: U.S.-focused apparel brands with enough monthly order volume to justify Pro pricing.

Margin Example at a \$25 Retail Price

Estimated gross profit before Shopify, card processing, ad costs, refunds, samples, and customer service time.

Service	Estimated Cost	Gross Profit at \$25	Gross Margin Before Platform/Payment Fees
Printify	~\$13.15	~\$11.85	~47%
Gooten	~\$13.60	~\$11.40	~46%
Gelato with Gelato+	~\$13.54	~\$11.46	~46%
CustomCat Pro	~\$13.66	~\$11.34	~45%
Gelato Free	~\$15.68	~\$9.32	~37%
Printful	~\$16.44	~\$8.56	~34%
CustomCat Lite	~\$16.46	~\$8.54	~34%

Final Recommendation

- Use Printify as the primary vendor for testing and margin control.
- Use Printful for premium products or any SKU where brand trust matters more than margin.
- Test CustomCat Pro if U.S. order volume becomes consistent enough to justify the monthly plan.
- Use Gelato if the store expands into international orders, posters, wall art, or global fulfillment.
- Keep Gooten on the radar for scale, but do not make it the primary vendor until sample quality and support reliability are proven.

Sample Testing Checklist

- Print sharpness and alignment
- Shirt fabric feel and fit consistency
- Wash test after 3-5 washes

- Packaging and presentation
- Actual order-to-delivery time
- Customer support response if there is an issue

Bottom Line

For crude/funny bartender shirts, the winning vendor is not just the cheapest one. It is the one that lets the business sell a shirt around \$28-\$32, protect the print quality after washing, and avoid spending excessive time apologizing to customers.

Source Notes

- Printify official app and comparison pages: product catalog, pricing plan, Shopify review data, provider/network details.
- Gooten official product and FAQ pages: Bella+Canvas 3001 pricing, production/shipping timing, network claims; Shopify app reviews.
- Gelato official pricing, product, shipping/delivery, and Shopify app pages: product pricing, Gelato+ pricing, global production network, review data.
- Printful official product, shipping, fulfillment, and Shopify app pages: Bella+Canvas 3001 pricing, fulfillment averages, shipping estimates, review data.
- CustomCat official product, pricing, shipping, and Shopify app pages: Lite/Pro product cost, Pro plan pricing, Detroit fulfillment, review data.